

Portugal

Beyond the Postcards

September 8 — September 22, 2026

14 nights · Designed for *Jennifer Oliver*

14 nights · A private Portugal journey



DATES

September 8 — September 22, 2026



ROUTE

Lisbon · Óbidos · Serra da Estrela · Gerês · Costa Vicentina



TRANSPORT

Automatic SUV · Airport pickup & return included



STATUS

All reservations confirmed



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This is your Portugal.

Fifteen days of one of Europe's most varied small countries — coastline, mountain, forest, cliff, Atlantic horizon. Every overnight stay is reserved. Every route is mapped. Every day has been designed with intention.

What follows is your complete private travel file. It begins with a summary of the six properties we have selected for you across the country — from a quiet hotel near central Lisbon, to a stone manor with views of medieval Óbidos castle, to a unique hotel beside a historic wool factory in the glacial valleys of Serra da Estrela, to a thermal spa hotel inside Portugal's only national park, to a brand-new boutique property in the heart of Vila Nova de Milfontes. Each was chosen to align with its region — not just to host you, but to deepen the experience of being there.

The day-by-day itinerary that follows is detailed but never rigid. Each day shows a suggested rhythm — morning, lunch, afternoon, sunset, evening — with the routes, road numbers and driving times that connect everything. A short italic context note appears on most days, offering historical, cultural or culinary background that will deepen the moments you live.

The route flows north from Lisbon along the Atlantic coast to medieval Óbidos and the dramatic cliffs of Nazaré and Peniche, then inland to the highest mountains in mainland Portugal, north again to the wild forests of Peneda-Gerês, and finally south to one of the most pristine coastlines in Europe — the Costa Vicentina — where you will spend three full days reaching as far south as Arrifana and Aljezur. The return to Lisbon on the final travel day follows the northern stretch of the same coast, through Porto Covo and the birthplace of Vasco da Gama, before crossing the Tejo back into the capital.

Need anything shaped differently? A local is always one message away.

· YOUR JOURNEY ·

Confirmed *reservations.*

Each of your fourteen nights in Portugal has been carefully selected and reserved. Full day-by-day detail begins on the following pages.

DATES	NIGHTS	PROPERTY	LOCATION	STATUS
Sep 8 — 9	1	OMID Saldanha Hotel	Lisbon	<i>Confirmed</i>
Sep 9 — 12	3	Casa d'Óbidos	Óbidos	<i>Confirmed</i>
Sep 12 — 15	3	Hotel da Fábrica	Manteigas · Serra da Estrela	<i>Confirmed</i>
Sep 15 — 18	3	Águas do Gerês Hotel, Termas & Spa	Vila do Gerês	<i>Confirmed</i>
Sep 18 — 21	3	Alentejo Charm House	Vila Nova de Milfontes	<i>Confirmed</i>
Sep 21 — 22	1	Olissippo Saldanha	Lisbon · near airport	<i>Confirmed</i>

· TRANSPORT ·

PICKUP	Lisbon Humberto Delgado Airport · September 8, 2026
RETURN	Lisbon Humberto Delgado Airport · September 22, 2026
VEHICLE	Automatic SUV · Tolls included via Via Verde

The *route*.

SEGMENT	BASE	NIGHTS	DATES	KEY ROADS
Lisbon — Arrival	Saldanha	1	Sep 8	IC17
West Coast — Medieval & Atlantic	Óbidos	3	Sep 9 — 11	A8
Serra da Estrela — Mountains	Manteigas	3	Sep 12 — 14	A1 · A23 · EN338
Gerês — Wild National Park	Vila do Gerês	3	Sep 15 — 17	A25 · A3 · EN308
Costa Vicentina — Atlantic South	Vila Nova de Milfontes	3	Sep 18 — 20	A1 · A2 · N120
Lisbon — Return via Coast	Saldanha · near airport	1	Sep 21	N120 · A2 · A5

The journey is built around *contrast*. It begins in Lisbon, then heads north along the Atlantic to medieval Óbidos and the dramatic cliffs of Nazaré and Peniche — Portugal at its most theatrical. From there, inland to the highest mountains in mainland Portugal, where stone villages still produce wool by hand and glaciers carved valleys 20,000 years ago. Further north to Peneda-Gerês, Portugal's only national park: granite, oak forest, Roman roads and wild ponies.

Then, after a long but spectacular drive south, the journey ends on the Costa Vicentina — three full days on one of the most pristine coastlines remaining in Europe. From your base at the heart of Vila Nova de Milfontes, the route reaches as far south as Aljezur and Arrifana, with their dramatic fortress cliffs. The return to Lisbon on the penultimate day follows the northern stretch of the same coast, through Porto Covo and Sines, before crossing the Tejo back into the capital.

· FIFTEEN DAYS ·

Day by *day*.

Each card shows your confirmed overnight stay in the dark band at the bottom. A context note in italics offers historical or cultural background. Routes, road numbers and timings are included for every transfer.

DAY 01

TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 8

Arrival in Lisbon

A soft and elegant introduction.

LISBON AIRPORT → SALDANHA · IC17 · 15 MIN · NO TOLL

AFTERNOON

Land at Lisbon Humberto Delgado Airport. Collect your automatic SUV at the rental counter inside the terminal — allow 30–45 minutes for paperwork and vehicle inspection. Drive 15 minutes via IC17 to OMID Saldanha Hotel in central Lisbon. Check in, shower, exhale.

LATE AFTERNOON

Walk Avenida da Liberdade — Lisbon's grand 19th-century boulevard, lined with plane trees, historic kiosks and tile-fronted buildings. Stop at Praça do Marquês de Pombal at the boulevard's head. First impressions of Lisbon begin here, on foot, slowly.

EVENING

Dinner in Chiado or Príncipe Real (10–15 minutes by taxi). For Lisbon classics: Solar dos Presuntos, a family-run institution since 1974. For modern Portuguese: A Cevicheria by Chef Kiko Martins, creative and intimate. Open the journey with a glass of Vinho Verde.

· CONTEXT ·

Lisbon was almost completely destroyed by the great earthquake of 1755 — one of the deadliest in European history. The Baixa district you'll cross was rebuilt on a strict grid by Marquês de Pombal, whose statue stands at the end of Avenida da Liberdade. It is considered one of Europe's first modern urban planning responses to natural disaster.

Hotel reception is 24h — late arrivals fully accommodated · Saldanha metro connects directly to the airport

AIRPORT → HOTEL · 15 MIN

OVERNIGHT

OMID Saldanha Hotel · Lisbon

Lisbon to Óbidos

Into medieval Portugal.

A8 NORTH · EXIT 15 ÓBIDOS · ~1H · TOLL ~€4

MORNING

Breakfast at the hotel. Depart by 10am. Take A8 north from Lisbon through pine forests and small Estremaduran farms. One hour later, the medieval silhouette of Óbidos rises from the plain: a complete walled town, painted white, trimmed in indigo blue and ochre yellow.

LATE MORNING

Park in the public lot outside the walls — cars not permitted inside. Enter through Porta da Vila, the main gate, decorated overhead with 18th-century azulejo tile panels. Walk Rua Direita, the cobbled spine of the village, past handmade ceramics, tiny bookstores and shop windows offering ginjinha.

LUNCH

Traditional lunch within the walls. Try açorda à alentejana (a bread-and- cilantro soup with poached egg), grilled fish, or arroz de marisco. Order a chocolate cup filled with ginjinha — sour cherry liqueur, an Óbidos specialty since the 17th century.

AFTERNOON

Walk the full circuit of the castle walls — 13th-century battlements with no guardrails, vertigo-inducing and unforgettable. Visit Igreja de Santa Maria, where a 10- year-old King Afonso V married his eight-year-old cousin in 1441.

EVENING

Check in at Casa d'Óbidos — a stone manor with the castle floating beyond the garden hedge. Dinner at the property or in the village. Sleep with the castle walls in view.

· CONTEXT ·

Óbidos was given by King Dinis I as a wedding gift to Queen Isabel in 1282. For nearly five centuries afterward, every Portuguese queen received the town on her wedding day — earning it the nickname Vila das Rainhas, the Town of Queens.

A8 toll: ~€4 Lisbon → Óbidos · Cars not allowed inside the walls — park outside

LISBON → ÓBIDOS · 1H VIA A8

OVERNIGHT

Casa d'Óbidos · Óbidos

Nazaré, Atlantic Cliffs & Peniche

Where Portugal feels raw and real.

N8 → N114 · COASTAL ROADS · NO TOLL

MORNING

Drive 45 minutes north on N8 to Nazaré. Drive up to Sítio, the clifftop neighbourhood 100 metres above the Atlantic. Visit the tiny chapel built where, in 1182, a knight was reportedly saved from falling off the cliff by a miraculous apparition.

LATE MORNING

Walk to the lighthouse — Forte de São Miguel Arcanjo, the famous big-wave viewpoint. Even in September, when waves are calmer, the offshore canyon creates dramatic swells. Many local women still wear the traditional seven skirts.

LUNCH

Seafood lunch in Nazaré town. Order caldeirada — Portuguese fish stew layering several species, potatoes, peppers and white wine — or grilled robalo (sea bass). Everything came from the harbour boats.

AFTERNOON

Continue south on N114 to Peniche, 40 minutes. Walk the dramatic Cabo Carvoeiro cliffs at the peninsula's tip — wind-sculpted rock formations, working lighthouse, raw Atlantic views. Drive 5 minutes to Baleal — a narrow tidal causeway with surfing on one side and a sheltered family beach on the other.

EVENING

Return to Óbidos. Slow dinner in the village — order porco à alentejana (pork with clams) and a Dão red wine.

· CONTEXT ·

Nazaré's giant waves are the result of the Nazaré Canyon — a 230 km-long underwater trench reaching depths of 5,000 metres just offshore. The canyon focuses ocean swells, amplifying them as they approach. World records for the biggest wave ever surfed have been set here repeatedly since 2011.

Optional: book the Berlengas Islands boat from Peniche — UNESCO reserve ·
Park outside Óbidos walls — no cars inside

LOOP: ÓBIDOS → NAZARÉ → PENICHE
→ ÓBIDOS · ~120 KM

OVERNIGHT

Casa d'Óbidos · Óbidos

A Slow Atlantic Day

A deliberate pause before the inland drive.

SHORT LOCAL DRIVES · N114 / EN360 · NO TOLL

MORNING

Slow breakfast at Casa d'Óbidos. Walk the village at its quietest — before the tour buses arrive, it belongs to those who slept inside it.

MIDDAY

Choose: drive 30 min south to São Martinho do Porto — a perfectly round sheltered bay, calm turquoise water ideal for swimming. Or drive 15 min north to Foz do Arelho, where a vast freshwater lagoon meets the ocean.

LUNCH

Light lunch at the beach. Grilled fish, simple green salad, a glass of Encostas d'Aire white.

AFTERNOON

Free. The property has gardens, a pool and quiet terraces. Read, swim, rest. Tomorrow's drive is long — today is a deliberate pause.

EVENING

Wine and seafood at a local adega. Ask for DOC Encostas d'Aire or a Vinho Regional Lisboa.

· CONTEXT ·

The Oeste wine region surrounding Óbidos has been producing wine since Roman times. Cool Atlantic winds keep grapes acidic and crisp — locally these wines are called vinhos do Oeste and rarely leave Portugal, despite being excellent value.

São Martinho do Porto: completely calm water, ideal swimming · Today is intentionally flexible — rest before the mountains

OPTIONAL LOOPS · 30 — 60 KM

OVERNIGHT

Casa d'Óbidos · Óbidos

Óbidos to Serra da Estrela

A complete shift in atmosphere.

A8 → A1 → A23 → EN338 · ~3H · TOLLS ~€10

MORNING

Depart Óbidos by 9am. Drive south on A8 to join A1, then east on A23 toward Castelo Branco and Covilhã. The landscape shifts from coastal plain to rolling Beira — vineyards, olive groves, granite outcrops and the silhouette of mountains ahead.

LUNCH

Stop in Fundão — a small town known for its cherries and cured ham. Order presunto, queijo da Serra fresco, broa de milho (corn bread) and a local red. 45- minute break.

AFTERNOON

Final leg on EN338 — a narrow mountain road descending into the Manteigas glacial valley. The road snakes through hairpins; the view opens to reveal a perfect U-shaped valley carved by ice 20,000 years ago. Stop at the Vale Glaciar viewpoint before the village. Check in at Hotel da Fábrica.

EVENING

Mountain dinner at the hotel: chanfana (kid goat slow-cooked in red wine), cozido da Serra, or truta do Zêzere (river trout). Drink a Dão red. Sleep with mountain air through the window.

· CONTEXT ·

Burel is a traditional dense wool fabric hand-woven in Serra da Estrela for centuries — originally to protect shepherds against extreme cold. Once nearly extinct, it was revived in the 2000s and is now used by international designers including Hermès. The Ecolã factory beside your hotel is the heart of this revival.

A23 tolls: ~€6 Abrantes → Covilhã · EN338 descent: slow for the views

ÓBIDOS → MANTEIGAS · 3H

OVERNIGHT

Hotel da Fábrica · Manteigas · Serra da Estrela

Glacier Peaks & Schist Villages

Portugal at its most authentic.

MOUNTAIN LOOP · EN338 · EN339 · EN232 · NO TOLL

MORNING

Drive EN338 up to Covão d'Ametade — a glacial lagoon at 1,400 metres. Short walk around the lake. The air at this height is cold, sharp and silent.

LATE MORNING

Continue on EN339 to Torre — the highest point in mainland Portugal at 1,993 metres. Open plateau, granite boulders, stone monument. On clear days the view extends across Spain. A small shop sells Burel garments and local cheese.

LUNCH

Drive south on EN232 to Piódão — a tiny village built entirely from schist, every door and window frame painted the same bright blue. Lunch at the village restaurant. One of Portugal's 12 Historic Villages, protected by national law.

AFTERNOON

Drive 20 minutes to Linhares da Beira — a medieval village on a granite ridge. Walk the 9th-century castle battlements. Views extend over the Mondego valley toward Spain.

EVENING

Return to Hotel da Fábrica. Optional: private tour of the Burel wool factory next door — the owner offers personal walks through the historic looms. Quiet mountain dinner.

· CONTEXT ·

Piódão was so isolated until the 1970s that the entire village shared one type of paint — the only colour sold by the single travelling merchant who reached the village was bright blue. Every door and window frame was painted the same shade. The detail is now protected by law.

Buy a whole queijo da Serra to take home · September is the best month — perfect weather, no crowds

LOOP FROM MANTEIGAS · ~120 KM

OVERNIGHT

Hotel da Fábrica · Manteigas · Serra da Estrela

A Slow Mountain Day

The reward of a third night in the mountains.

SHORT LOCAL DRIVES OR WALKS · NO TOLL

MORNING Slow breakfast at Hotel da Fábrica. No agenda. The mountain air at this hour is the reason people return to Manteigas every year of their lives.

MIDDAY Optional walks. Trilho do Poço do Inferno (Hell's Well Trail) is a short 2 km loop to a dramatic waterfall in a granite canyon. Or drive 10 minutes to Caldas de Manteigas — a small thermal spa village with public baths fed by hot mineral springs.

LUNCH Lunch in Manteigas village. Order something you haven't yet tried — feijocas (white bean stew), arroz de pato à moda de Manteigas (local duck rice), or rabbit hunter-style.

AFTERNOON Free. The hotel has an indoor pool, sauna and spa — use it. Or read on the terrace with the glacial valley spread out below. Today is the pause between mountains and forest.

EVENING Final dinner in Serra da Estrela. Pair regional cheese with a glass of Port wine — an old shepherd's tradition.

· CONTEXT ·

Manteigas was once one of the most isolated villages in Portugal — until the 1950s the only access was by mule track. The valley below the village is a textbook glacial U-shape, carved by the Estrela glacier during the last Ice Age. Geologists consider it one of the most pristine glacial valleys in southern Europe.

Poço do Inferno: short walk to a 10-metre waterfall · Caldas de Manteigas thermal baths: public, simple, ancient

LOCAL ONLY · 20 — 40 KM

OVERNIGHT

Hotel da Fábrica · Manteigas · Serra da Estrela

Serra da Estrela to Gerês

Wild, green and completely immersive.

A25 WEST → A3 NORTH → EN308 · ~3H · TOLLS ~€9

MORNING

Depart by 9am. Drive west on A25 toward Aveiro, then north on A3 toward Braga. Optional 30-minute stop in Viseu — historic city, Romanesque cathedral and excellent pastries.

LUNCH

Lunch near Braga or in a roadside Minho restaurant. Northern cuisine is richer: rojões, caldo verde, broa de milho. Drink local Vinho Verde — slightly sparkling, low in alcohol.

AFTERNOON

Enter Gerês via EN308 from Braga — one of the most beautiful drives in Portugal. The road climbs through granite boulders, ancient oak and pine forest, occasional waterfalls. Wild Garrano ponies appear on the roadside.

EVENING

Arrive Vila do Gerês. Check in at Águas do Gerês — historic thermal hotel with mineral pools, spa and gardens. Dinner: arroz de pato or bacalhau à Braga.

· CONTEXT ·

Peneda-Gerês is Portugal's only national park, created in 1971. It protects 70,000 hectares of mountains, forest, rivers and traditional villages. The park includes Roman roads, Bronze Age sites, megalithic monuments and the only wild wolf population in southern Europe.

A3 tolls: ~€9 from Serra da Estrela region · Slow on EN308 — Garrano ponies roam the road

MANTEIGAS → VILA DO GERÊS · 3H

OVERNIGHT

Águas do Gerês Hotel, Termas & Spa · Vila do Gerês

Waterfalls, Hiking & Thermal Pools

Nature not curated — alive.

PARK INTERIOR · EN308 · EN203 · NO TOLL

MORNING

Drive EN308 to Ermida. Hike to Cascata do Arado — one of the most beautiful waterfalls in Portugal. 5 km round trip, easy to moderate, winding through oak forest and granite. The waterfall drops 60 metres into a natural pool. Swim if you wish — cold but exhilarating.

MIDDAY

Picnic lunch beside the water (the hotel can prepare one), or return to Vila do Gerês. Afterward, use the hotel's mineral-rich thermal pools — open through September.

AFTERNOON

Drive EN203 to Castro Laboreiro — an ancient granite village near the Spanish border. Visit the medieval castle ruins on the hill. Famous for the Castro Laboreiro dog, bred to protect livestock from wolves.

EVENING

Sunset from Miradouro da Pedra Bela — panoramic viewpoint over the Caniçada reservoir and surrounding peaks. Dinner back at the hotel.

· CONTEXT ·

The villages of Gerês still practice vezeira — a communal grazing system where each family takes turns shepherding the entire village's cattle high into the mountains. The practice is over 1,000 years old and is still functioning in remote villages like Pitões das Júnias and Tourém.

Cascata do Arado: follow blue and yellow markers from Ermida · Bring water, swimwear and a towel

PARK LOOPS · 60 — 80 KM

OVERNIGHT

Águas do Gerês Hotel, Termas & Spa · Vila do Gerês

Roman Roads & Submerged Villages

Ancient paths through ancient land.

PARK INTERIOR · BORRAGEIRO ROUTE · NO TOLL

MORNING

Optional: half-day canyoning or kayaking on the Cávado river. Local operators — Trilhos & Emoções or Gerês Activo. Alternative: slower morning walking the forest trails near the hotel.

LUNCH

Traditional restaurant in Vila do Gerês. Order presunto bísaro (local cured ham), posta barrosã (thick-cut local beef, char-grilled), or a hearty cabbage and bean stew.

AFTERNOON

Drive the Borrageiro route. Roman milestones of the Via XVII line the ancient road from Braga to Astorga. Visit Vilarinho das Furnas dam viewpoint. In dry Septembers, the submerged walls of the 1972 village emerge from the receding reservoir — haunting and beautiful.

EVENING

Final Gerês dinner. Order arroz de pato or posta barrosã if not yet tried. Recap the journey so far over a glass of local Vinho Verde tinto — rare, slightly sour, only found in the north.

· CONTEXT ·

Vilarinho das Furnas was a granite village inhabited continuously for 2,000 years before being flooded by a dam in 1972. Its 80 families were relocated; their stone houses now sit beneath the reservoir. When water levels drop in late summer, the walls reappear — a physical record of rural displacement.

Canyoning: book one day in advance · Vilarinho walls: most visible when reservoir is low

SHORT PARK DRIVES · 40 — 60 KM

OVERNIGHT

Águas do Gerês Hotel, Termas & Spa · Vila do Gerês

Gerês to Costa Vicentina

A long drive south — and everything changes.

A3 → A1 → A2 → N120 · ~5H · TOLLS ~€25

MORNING

Early departure by 8am — this is the longest drive of the trip, but the smoothest. A3 south to Porto, A1 south past Coimbra and Leiria, then A2 into the Alentejo plains. Cross the Tejo on the iconic 25 de Abril or Vasco da Gama bridge.

LUNCH

Lunch in Grândola or Santiago do Cacém — Alentejo towns with whitewashed houses and excellent regional food. Order pão alentejano, queijo de Azeitão, açorda alentejana, or grilled black pork (porco preto). Pair with a glass of Alentejo red.

AFTERNOON

Final leg on N120 — a quiet coastal road into Vila Nova de Milfontes. The landscape flattens, whitens, opens to the sea. Cork-oak trees line the road, their bark harvested every nine years. Check in at Alentejo Charm House — a boutique property in the heart of the village, with rooftop pool and views over Milfontes.

EVENING

Beach walk along the Mira river mouth — where freshwater meets Atlantic. Seafood dinner on the harbour: arroz de lingueirão (razor clam rice, the Milfontes specialty), ameijoas à Bulhão Pato, or fresh grilled robalo.

· CONTEXT ·

The Alentejo region produces some of Portugal's most distinctive food and wine, shaped by centuries of Moorish and Christian rural tradition. Cork from this region supplies most of the world's wine corks — the cork-oak trees are protected by law and only harvested every nine years. Each tree lives 200 years.

Long drive day — leave early, build in two stops · Milfontes September water:
~22°C — warm enough for long swims

VILA DO GERÊS → MILFONTES · 5H

OVERNIGHT

Alentejo Charm House · Vila Nova de Milfontes

South to Odeceixe, Aljezur & Arrifana

Where the southwest coast becomes theatrical.

N120 SOUTH · MILFONTES → ODECEIXE → ALJEZUR → ARRIFANA

MORNING

Slow breakfast at Alentejo Charm House. Depart by 9:30am driving south on N120. The landscape becomes wilder: cliffs, gorse, wind-bent pines and the first hints of the Algarve.

LATE MORNING

Praia de Odeceixe — 30 min from Milfontes. The beach sits where the Seixe river meets the Atlantic: freshwater calm on one side, ocean surf on the other. One of the most beautiful and peaceful coves on the entire Vicentina coast.

MIDDAY

Continue south to Aljezur, 15 min. Walk up to the 10th-century Moorish castle ruins on the hilltop — 360° views over cork-oak hills and the Atlantic. The town below is lined with sweet-potato stalls — the region has protected geographical indication for its unique variety.

AFTERNOON

Drive to Praia da Arrifana, 20 min from Aljezur. A perfect crescent bay enclosed by sheer red and yellow cliffs, with the ruined Fortaleza da Arrifana fortress perched dramatically at the headland. Walk down to the beach for a swim, then climb to the fortress ruins for one of the most photographed views in Portugal.

SUNSET

Stay at Arrifana for sunset, or drive 10 min north to Praia de Monte Clérigo — quieter, longer beach, equally dramatic cliffs. The sun touching the Atlantic from these clifftops in September is the visual climax of the entire journey.

EVENING

Drive back to Milfontes, 1h return via N120. Late celebratory dinner — fresh grilled fish, percebes (gooseneck barnacles) if in season, a special Alentejo white. Linger.

· CONTEXT ·

The Fortaleza da Arrifana was built in 1635 to defend the coast from Algerian pirates who repeatedly raided the southwest throughout the 17th century. It was largely destroyed by the 1755 earthquake and tsunami. Aljezur was the last Moorish-controlled town in Portugal, retaken by Christian forces only in 1249.

Park early at Arrifana — small lot, fills by midday · Bring wind protection — the southwest coast is always exposed

**MILFONTES → ARRIFANA & RETURN ·
~180 KM**

OVERNIGHT

Alentejo Charm House · Vila Nova de Milfontes

Fishermen's Trail, Porto Covo & Slow Atlantic

The final day to simply be here.

COASTAL TRAIL · N393 NORTH TO PORTO COVO · LOCAL

MORNING

Walk a section of the Trilho dos Pescadores — Fishermen's Trail — clifftop paths above the Atlantic between Milfontes and Almogrove. The 8 km one-way section is mostly flat with extraordinary views. Alternatively: a shorter 3 km walk to the Milfontes lighthouse and back.

MIDDAY

Drive N393 north to Porto Covo, 20 minutes. A tiny whitewashed fishing village, perfectly preserved, with cobblestone streets and a shaded main square. Ilheu do Pessegueiro lies just offshore — a small island holding the ruined 16th-century Forte de Santo Albano. Lunch at a local tasca — order whatever arrived on the boats.

AFTERNOON

Return to Milfontes. Free afternoon: beach, rooftop pool at the hotel, or simply explore the village on foot. The old town is small enough to walk in 20 minutes, with a castle terrace, riverside cafés and artisan shops. Praia da Franquia — the town beach — is sheltered and calm. Or walk to Praia do Malhão, 30 minutes north through dunes.

SUNSET

Final sunset on the Costa Vicentina. The rooftop at Alentejo Charm House overlooks the village at this hour — golden light, sea breeze, a glass of wine.

EVENING

Quiet last dinner in Milfontes. Order something you didn't try yet. Pack tonight.

· CONTEXT ·

The Rota Vicentina is a 750 km network of trails preserving one of the last undeveloped coastlines in Europe. Created in 2012 by a partnership of local hotels and conservationists, it is now considered one of the world's great walking routes. The Fishermen's Trail section follows paths once used by villagers walking to harvest barnacles from the rocks.

Praia do Malhão: 30-min coastal walk north · Pack tonight — tomorrow is a driving day

LOCAL COASTAL DRIVES · 30 — 60 KM

OVERNIGHT

Alentejo Charm House · Vila Nova de Milfontes

Return North: Sines & Lisbon

The coast you have not yet seen — before the city closes around you again.

N120 NORTH → SINES → A2 → A12 → A5 · ~3H WITH STOPS

MORNING

Final slow breakfast. Pack and depart by 10am. The route to Lisbon today takes the northern coastal road — a deliberate choice over the faster inland motorway.

LATE MORNING

Stop again in Porto Covo if you wish, or push on. Coffee in the small main square, last view of Ilheu do Pessegueiro offshore.

MIDDAY

Continue north to Sines, 30 minutes — the birthplace of Vasco da Gama, who set sail from here to India in 1497. Park near the medieval castle and walk the old town. Grilled sardines for lunch at a harbourside restaurant — Sines is famous for them.

AFTERNOON

Drive A2 north toward Lisbon. Cross the Tejo via the Vasco da Gama bridge (12 km long, the longest in Europe when opened in 1998). Arrive Lisbon mid- afternoon. Check in at Olisippo Saldanha. Optional: stop in Belém (Pastéis de Belém, Jerónimos Monastery, Belém Tower) — 20 minutes from the hotel.

EVENING

Final dinner in Lisbon. Celebratory — Príncipe Real or Chiado. Order the full menu, share a special bottle: a Pêra-Manca or Mouchão from the Alentejo, or a Niepoort from the Douro. Toast the journey.

· CONTEXT ·

Vasco da Gama was born in Sines around 1469 and grew up watching the Atlantic from this small fishing town. In 1497 he led the first European naval expedition to reach India by sea — a voyage that opened the spice trade routes and reshaped global commerce for the next four centuries. His house in Sines is now a small museum.

Olisippo Saldanha: direct metro to the airport — 20 min on the red line · Pre-pack tonight — tomorrow morning's departure is smooth

MILFONTES → LISBON (SALDANHA) · 3H WITH STOPS

OVERNIGHT

Olisippo Saldanha · Lisbon · near airport

Departure

Portugal will feel different from here on.

METRO RED LINE OR 10-MIN DRIVE TO AIRPORT

MORNING

Final breakfast at the hotel. Pack last items. Drive 10 minutes to Lisbon airport and return the rental car at the terminal counter. Allow 45 minutes for car return and a minimum of 2 hours before international flight departure.

DEPARTURE

Airport check-in. Final coffee and pastel de nata. Optional duty-free: queijo da Serra (vacuum-packed for travel), Alentejo wine, flor de sal from the Sado estuary, hand-painted ceramics from Óbidos.

· CONTEXT ·

You leave with fifteen days of one of Europe's most varied small countries — Atlantic coastline, mountain peaks, oak forest, medieval walls, ocean cliff. The journey is the souvenir.

Hotel → Airport: 10 min by car or 20 min via metro red line · Buy souvenirs at the airport — selection is good

HOTEL → AIRPORT · 10 MIN

Your *accommodations*.

Each property has been selected for its alignment with the region, the rhythm of the journey, and the experience you came to Portugal for.

OMID Saldanha Hotel

Lisbon · Sep 8 – 9 · 1 night

Modern 4-star hotel in the Saldanha district, well-connected to the airport via metro red line. Memory-foam beds, rain showers, Netflix in rooms, terrace bar, and a business centre. Excellent staff. The ideal first night after a long transatlantic flight — clean, comfortable, and easy to navigate when tired. Generous buffet breakfast included.

Casa d'Óbidos

Óbidos · Sep 9 – 12 · 3 nights

Stone manor house with direct views of Óbidos castle. Set in private gardens just outside the medieval walls — quieter than properties inside, with easy walking access to the village. Pool, antique furnishings, gardens that smell of jasmine in late summer. Breakfast served in the garden when weather permits. One of the most atmospheric small hotels on Portugal's west coast.

Hotel da Fábrica

Manteigas · Serra da Estrela · Sep 12 – 15 · 3 nights

Unique 4-star property built around the historic Burel wool factory at the heart of the Manteigas glacial valley. Indoor pool, sauna, spa, and a terrace with panoramic mountain views. The breakfast is personalised — chosen the night before from a list and waiting at your table in the morning. The owner offers private tours of the adjacent Ecolã factory, where Burel wool has been produced for generations. Genuinely special.

Águas do Gerês Hotel, Termas & Spa

Vila do Gerês · Sep 15 – 18 · 3 nights

Historic thermal spa hotel located inside Peneda-Gerês National Park. Outdoor mineral-water pools, wellness centre, and restaurant Essentia featuring local ingredients. Surrounded by ancient oak forest and granite landscape. Walking distance to park trails and the small thermal village. One of the highest-rated properties in the Gerês region — a rare combination of historical character and modern comfort.

Alentejo Charm House

Vila Nova de Milfontes · Sep 18 – 21 · 3 nights

Boutique property in the centre of Vila Nova de Milfontes — eight unique suites where traditional Alentejo character meets contemporary interior design. Rooftop pool with views over the village and ocean horizon; a perfect place to watch the sun touch the Atlantic. Self-service shared kitchen for relaxed mornings, with a continental breakfast featuring the freshest regional produce. On foot from cafés, pastry shops, the market, São Clemente Fort and Praia da Franquia. Quiet, refined, and authentic.

Olisippo Saldanha

Lisbon · near airport · Sep 21 – 22 · 1 night

Stylish 4-star hotel in Saldanha — central but with quick airport access via metro red line. Modern rooms with balconies, buffet breakfast, good restaurants within walking distance. Excellent for the final night: direct metro line to the airport, and the comfort of a real city hotel before departure.

Practical *notes*.

Roads & Tolls

- All motorway tolls are included in your rental via Via Verde (installed in the vehicle).
- EN (Estrada Nacional) roads are toll-free and used intentionally throughout this route.
- Speed limits: 120 km/h motorway, 90 km/h rural, 50 km/h urban. Speed cameras are common — observe limits strictly.
- Parking is free in most small villages. City centres use paid blue-zone parking — pay at meters or via EasyPark mobile app.
- Download offline maps for the Gerês interior before leaving Braga — signal is weak in deep forest.

Weather — September 2026

- Lisbon & Costa Vicentina: 24–28°C by day, very low rain probability, sunshine most days.
- Serra da Estrela: 15–22°C by day, dropping to 10°C at night — a warm layer is essential.
- Gerês: 18–24°C, slightly more humid. Morning mist is possible in the valleys.
- Atlantic sea temperature: 20–22°C — comfortably swimmable throughout.

What to Pack

- Trail shoes with grip — for Gerês waterfalls and Serra da Estrela peaks.
- Light waterproof jacket or windbreaker for mountain mornings and the Vicentina coast.
- Swimwear — you will swim in rivers, reservoirs, glacial lakes and Atlantic beaches.
- Sun protection: September sun is still strong, especially on the coast.
- One smart-casual outfit for the celebratory final dinners.
- Reusable water bottle — Portuguese tap water is excellent throughout the country.

Food & Wine

- Lunch (almoço) is the best-value meal — prato do dia set menus €10–15.
- Pastel de Nata: buy from a local padaria, never a chain. Best in Belém on the final day.
- Seafood: always ask what arrived that morning — freshness is non-negotiable on the Portuguese coast.
- Wines by region: Vinho Verde (Gerês), Alentejo reds (Milfontes), Oeste whites (Óbidos), Dão (Serra da Estrela).
- Tipping: not mandatory in Portugal but 5–10% is appreciated for good service.

Local Support

- WhatsApp works everywhere in Portugal — all hotels provide WiFi.
- Your YES experiences Portugal contact is one message away throughout the journey.
- All hotels have English-speaking reception staff.
- In emergencies: 112 is the European emergency number, available throughout Portugal.

Your local team is one message away — before, during & after the journey.

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